

Closely contested for this position was the Samsung YP D1, with the same storage capacity and bundled with features. Samsung have put in an excellent 2MP camera! Be it a vacation or an award ceremony, recording sights and sounds besides listening to great music, all a single device, is something anyone would want. But for its MRP of Rs 21,500, it could have been the Gold winner. As it stands, it has to make do with the Digit Best Buy Silver.

Other players that grace the hall of fame—but just about missed out on being winners—are the Apple iPod nano with its 4 GB of memory, the Samsung YP C1, Cowon iAudio U2, SAFA M820 and M850, Transcend T.Sonic 610, and the YES YMP 920, 921, 922 and 928.

HARD DRIVE-BASED PLAYERS

Thus far, we've looked at plenty of Flash-based players, and there's a good chance you've already settled for one. But don't rush out to buy just yet—there are the hard drive players to look at as well!

Flash-based players are more rugged and less prone to damage than those running on a hard drive. This is because a hard drive has moving parts. Flash-based players are thus to be preferred where chances of the device falling or bumping are high.

Despite this advantage, the primary drawback of Flash-based players is their storage capacities. They generally don't offer over 4 GB. Moreover, as the capacity nears the 4 GB mark, the cost of the product shoots up exponentially. This is where hard drive-based players come in.

Players built around hard drives start from 5 GB and routinely touch the 60 GB mark. Some even go up to 120 GB. Generally, these players are expensive, starting at little over Rs 10K and crossing the 30K line.

Taking advantage of the huge space on offer, manufacturers are looking to develop this category into Portable Media Center players. Such players will play songs, videos, and record video; they'll include PDA tools and many such advanced features.

In order to cram higher capacities into smaller form factors, HDD-based players now employ tiny microdrives. MP3 players belonging to both types—regular hard drive and micro-drive—have been tested here.

This category saw six players, three of them HDD-based and three microdrive-based, from three manufacturers—Apple, Sony, and Creative.

Since we conducted such a test only a few months ago—in October 2005—we were afraid there would be a repetition of products in the current test. But to our surprise, we have four new players in this category, along with the Creative Zen Vision, which we've featured separately.

A Look At Features

Apart from greater capacities, let us see what these players offer that their Flash-based counterparts do not.

The Display

For the price tag attached to these players, one would expect colour displays at the least. But to

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